

no longer needed by major applications. One notable application that was still using GTK2, Ardour, has also been updated to remove this dependency in its 8.4 release.

KaOS Linux has been at the forefront of adopting the KDE Plasma 6 desktop environment, being one of the first distributions to offer a “pure Plasma 6-based environment” with its 2024.01 release, which included the second Release Candidate of Plasma 6.

The latest KaOS Linux 2024.03 release aims to provide a more stable Plasma 6 desktop experience. It ships with KDE Plasma 6.0.1, along with the KDE Gear 24.02 and KDE Frameworks 6.0 software suites. This update is designed to offer users a reliable and modern desktop environment for their personal computers.

Under the hood, KaOS Linux 2024.03 is powered by the Linux 6.7 kernel series, specifically Linux kernel 6.7.9. It also includes the latest Mesa 24.0.2 graphics stack, GStreamer 1.24 multimedia framework, GCC 13.2.1, GNU C Library 2.39, GNU Binutils 2.42, systemd 253.17, OpenZFS 2.2.3, OpenSSL 3.2, and OpenCV 4.9.0.

The announcement reads: “Highlights of this new version include two major upgrades: a transition to the latest version of our application framework, Qt, and a migration to the modern Linux graphics platform, Wayland. These under-the-hood upgrades benefit Plasma’s security, efficiency, and performance, and improve support for modern hardware.”

This release introduces a new package called SystemdGenie, developed by KDE to integrate *systemd* management into the Plasma 6 desktop seamlessly. KaOS Linux 2024.03 is available for download from the official website.

Linux Kernel 6.8 officially released

Linus Torvalds has announced the release and general availability of Linux kernel 6.8, the latest stable version of the Linux kernel with several new features and improvements.



Highlights of Linux kernel 6.8 include:

- LAM (linear address masking) virtualisation and guest-first memory support for KVM
- Basic online file system check and repair mechanism for the Bcachefs file system

- Support for the Broadcom BCM2712 processor in Raspberry Pi 5
- AMD ACPI-based Wi-Fi band RFI mitigation feature (WBRF)
- Zswap writeback disabling
- Fscrypt support for CephFS
- New Intel Xe DRM driver
- Multi-size THP (transparent huge pages) sysfs interface

Several hardware support improvements have been implemented in Linux kernel 6.8. These include the addition of IRQ override quirks for ASUS ExpertBook B1502CGA and ASUS Vivobook E1504GA/E1504GAB laptops, some TUXEDO InfinityBook Pro laptops, and other TongFang GMxXGxx models. Support has also been added for the Acer Predator PHN16-71 laptop, along with a new driver for Silicom network appliance EC LEDs and GPIOs. Additionally, there are AMD PMC / PMF improvements and new platform support, as well as Intel PMC / PMT / TPMI / uncore-freq / vsec improvements and new platform support.

The update also brings improvements to various drivers. The WMI bus driver has been enhanced, while the intel_pstate cpufreq driver now supports Emerald Rapids in no-HWP mode. The ACPI thermal zone driver supports thermal fast sampling period (TFP), and the AMDGPU driver now includes colour management support for the Steam Deck. A new driver has been added to support the Adafruit Seesaw gamepad device. Several enhancements have also been made for Android devices.

Linux kernel 6.8 is set to be a short-lived branch with support for only a couple of months. Its successor, Linux kernel 6.9, is already in development, with Linus Torvalds officially opening the merge window. Linux kernel 6.9 is expected to be released in mid-May 2024.



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